Lahore from gaining control over the plane. Again if the hijackers only had dummy weapons, who supplied them the detonating devices to blow up the plane?

Indian and US officials agreed that Pakistan couldn't escape responsibility. The US told Pakistan to either return the hijackers or prosecute them. Meanwhile, Indian intelligence operatives were told by their US counterparts that the 'US government would not like to get involved between the two countries.'

The message was clear. The USA was not interested in helping India on this issue at the cost of antagonising Pakistan, which it thought was a force to counter Indian hegemony in the South Asia region. Till 1971, Indian agencies believed that the USA tended to build up Pakistan as a counter to India in an attempt to maintain a balance of power in the subcontinent. But R&AW deputy director M.C. Pant in a note dated 26 June 1973 said the US outlook was changing. He said, 'During a private conversation in London where Daniel Patrick Moynihan, the US ambassador to India, had gone in the second week of May 1973 to attend a function at the London School of Economics and Political Science, he is reported to have expressed optimism regarding Indo-American relations. According to him, the American administration had realised that it had made some mistakes in its policies concerning the sub-continent during 1971 and that it was prepared to normalise and improve its relations with India.'

But as in any bilateral relationship, suspicions always remained. On 13 June 1973, foreign secretary Kewal Singh warned the Indian ambassador to the US, T.N. Kaul, that the USA was trying to create a rift between India and its neighbours.